

Unit Y310: The Development of the Nation State: France 1498–1610

This theme focuses on the theory and practice of concepts of a French 'nation state' in the reigns of Louis XII, Francis I, Henry II, Francis II, Charles IX, Henry III and Henry IV. The theme deals with French domestic affairs within the context of the important changes in Europe during this period but learners will not be tested on other countries. The strands identified below are not to be studied in isolation to each other.

Learners are not expected to demonstrate a detailed understanding of the specification content, except for the named in-depth studies, but are expected to know the main developments and turning points relevant to the theme. Foreign policy should be studied only to a level appropriate for an understanding of its impact on the theme of the domestic nation state.

Thematic Study: The Development of the Nation State: France 1498–1610	
Key Topics	Content Learners should have studied the following:
The Monarchy and central government	Royal impact on stability and the development of the nation state; the authority, domestic rule and reputations of the French monarchs 1498–1610; the extent of their power and centralised authority; the role of the nobility, the extent of unification, centralisation and absolutism.
Law, provincial government and society	The development of language, customs, legal codes and courts; taxation and privileges; the extent of royal control of the provinces, provincial estates and the role of the provinces in the development of the nation state; feudal loyalties and provincialism; noble privileges and clientage, their impact on strengthening and limiting royal power, including the rebellion of Constable Bourbon (1523).
Religion and the Church	The impact of religion in the development of the nation state; the role of the Catholic Church; the extent of religious disunity, humanism, Lutheranism and Calvinism, contribution to the civil wars and to stability.
The impact of wars on French stability and unification	The impact on stability and on the development of the nation state; the Habsburg-Valois Wars 1498–1559: legacy for the nation state and as a cause of the French civil wars; the French Wars of Religion 1562–1598: an overall assessment of the comparative contribution of wars to the development of the French nation state.

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Depth Studies	Content Learners should be aware of debates surrounding the issues outlined for each in-depth topic:
Francis I and ‘Renaissance Monarchy’	Powers as monarch; strengths and limitations; theories of absolutism; his relations with the Church, the law, the Parlements, nobility and office holders; financial weaknesses; political, religious and legal restraints; his use of venality; Fontainebleau, his patronage of the arts and French culture.
The Massacre of St Bartholomew 1572	Causes, context of the civil wars and of Paris in August 1572, the Bourbon marriage and resulting influx of Huguenots; factional feuds; Coligny: his influence on Charles IX, his aims concerning the Netherlands Revolt; the role of Catherine de’ Medici and the Guise; atrocities and their spread to the provinces; the death toll and impact.
Henry IV	The Navarre inheritance; religious affiliation and conversion; his character, military abilities; the impact of the assassination of Henry III, problems of accession; the situation in 1593; defeat of the Spanish and ending of the civil wars (1598); the Edict of Nantes (1598), acceptance of the Jesuits (1599); political, religious, economic and military achievements; the achievements of Sully; his assassination and legacy to his heir.